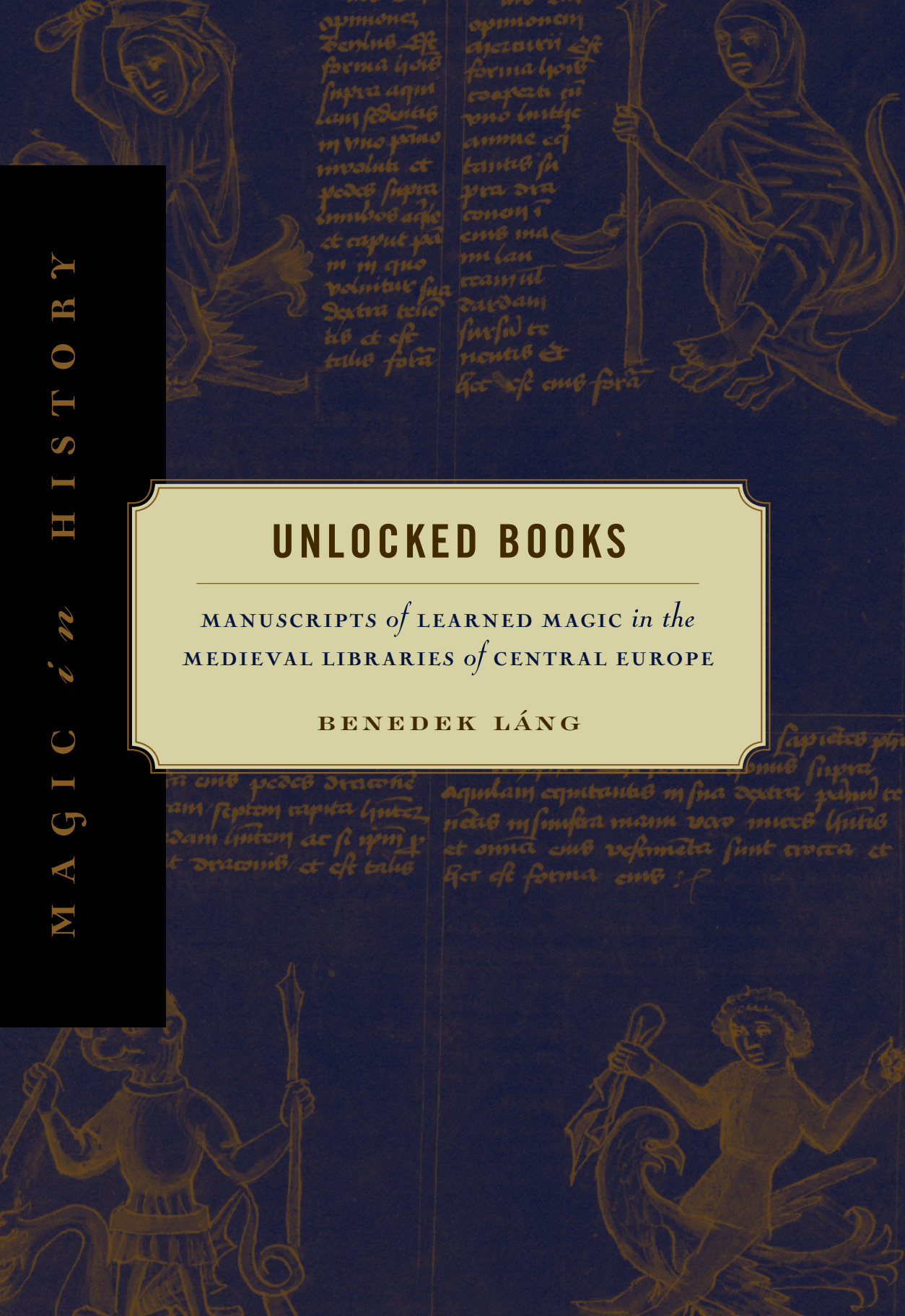


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MAGIC IN HISTORY

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MANUSCRIPTS OF LEARNED MAGIC
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OF CENTRAL EUROPE

BENEDEK LÁNG

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INTRODUCTION: IN SEARCH OF MAGICIAN SCHOOLS

There is a rather curious handwritten note in the first page of the British Library's copy of a printed reference book that was widely read in the sixteenth century, the *Locorum communium collectanea* by Johannes Manlius, "In this interesting book the first authentic notice of the Magician Dr Faustus is to be found at p. 43."¹ On page 43, following a report on Abbot Trithemius (who, according to the author, was a great magician), there are indeed a few paragraphs on the famous figure whose legend soon became a popular literary topic. There it states that Faustus, "when he was a student in Kraków, studied magic, as this art was at the time widely used and publicly practiced there."² This statement appears in Manlius's book as part of common knowledge, and it soon became in fact generally accepted. Another, slightly later source relying heavily on Manlius, the *Dies caniculares* by Simon Maiolus, repeats the claims that a Johannes Faustus studied magic in Kraków, where—according to Maiolus—it was publicly taught.³

The general approval of a proposition, however, is not necessarily related to its truth value. This sentence, for example, has a number of untrue implications. It asserts, first of all, that the man who was to become the archetype of human dealings with the devil did exist and was called Johannes. Now, philological investigations have established that the historical Faustus did indeed exist, but he was not called Johannes at all, but rather Georgius. Second, Manlius says that he studied in Kraków—at least for a time. Again, this seems to be false, for there is no historical

1. British Library, London, 12209.b.1.

2. "Hic cum esset scholasticus Cracoviensis, ibi magiam didicerat, sicut ibi olim fuit ejus magnus usus, et ibidem fuerunt publicae ejusdem artis professiones." Johannes Manlius, *Locorum communium collectanea* (Basel: Johannes Oporius, 1563), 43.

3. "Johannes Faustus qui Cracoviae magiam, ubi ea publice olim docebatur, didicerat." Simon Maiolus, *Dies Caniculares* (Moguntiae: Johannes Theobaldus Schönmetter, 1615), 601.

evidence that Faustus was ever in Poland.⁴ Finally, Manlius explicitly states that Faustus went to Kraków to study magic because this art was publicly practiced—in Maiolus's words, even instructed—in the famous university town.

It is widely known that according to certain popular beliefs, magicians were wandering students who learned magic from books by great intellectual effort in special schools.⁵ Such schools were located, for example, in Salamanca and Toledo. It is quite understandable why these Iberian towns had such a reputation: they were located at the meeting point of three—the Arabic, the Christian, and the Jewish—cultures, and it was through them that the Latin Middle Ages imported the new learning. This was where the Western world had been confronted with—and started to translate—the Arabic scientific corpus. This cultural import included at least as much astrology, talismanic magic, and alchemy as mathematics, philosophy, optics, and physics. It is not surprising, therefore, that a whole tradition of *topoi* had presented Toledo as an international center of the black arts, divination, and demonic magic, ever since the first scientific and magical texts were translated.⁶ This conviction was so strong that the “notory art,” described in a widespread text of medieval ritual magic, the *Ars notoria*, was also called the “art of Toledo.”⁷ To give another example: a source pertaining to the same genre of learned magic, the *Liber iuratus Honorii* (Sworn Book of Honorius) purports to report a general synod of magicians arriving from three cities: Naples, Athens, and Toledo. Even as late as the sixteenth century, François Rabelais wrote of a “*faculté diabolique*” functioning in Toledo.⁸

However, why Kraków had a reputation as a center of magic is far from being so

4. Frank Baron, *Doctor Faustus: From History to Legend* (Munich: Wilhelm Fink Verlag, 1978), 11–16 and 84.

5. See Ladislaus Toth, “Savoir et pouvoir par les livres de magie,” *Aries* 15 (1993): 13–25, on folk beliefs. On the literary tradition concerning schools of magic, see P. Jacoby, “Hochschulen der Zauberei,” in *Handwörterbuch des deutschen Aberglaubens*, ed. Hanns Bächtold-Stäubli, 10 vols. (Leipzig: Walter de Gruyter, 1927–42). On the image of the magician (especially Virgil, Talesin, Merlin, Michael Scot, and Roger Bacon) in medieval popular beliefs, see Juliette Wood, “Virgil and Talesin: The Concept of the Magician in Medieval Folklore,” *Folklore* 94 (1983): 91–104.

6. The first Latin authors responsible for this tradition were William of Malmesbury and Caesarius of Heisterbach; see Klaus Herbers, “Wissensk kontakte und Wissensvermittlung in Spanien,” in *Artes im Mittelalter*, ed. Ursula Schaefer (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1999), esp. 244–47, and Jacoby, “Hochschulen der Zauberei.”

7. Among other examples, it was thus called by the fourteenth-century Burgundian Laurens Pignon; see Jan R. Veenstra, *Magic and Divination in Burgundy and France: Text and Context of Laurens Pignon's “Contre les devineurs” (1411)* (Leiden: Brill, 1998), 293–94. Since the *Ars notoria* describes exactly the kind of magic that provides better memory and competence in the liberal arts, the association of Toledo with the notory art is a telling indication that proficiency in the new learning and magic were intermingled.

8. François Rabelais, *Pantagruel: Le Tiers Livre*, in *Oeuvres complètes* (Paris: Librairie Gallimard, 1951), 3:433.

obvious. While it might have been a commonplace in Manlius's times that Kraków had once been a center for magical studies, it is far from evident today what the source of this conviction was. Did Kraków really possess a particularly magical milieu?

My book has succeeded if, by its end, its readers feel that they have received sufficient information to answer this question. More precisely, I will focus on not only Kraków but all of Central Europe, as seen through contemporary manuscripts. Even though I cannot promise to identify a public school for the black arts functioning in the medieval territories of Poland, Hungary, or Bohemia—as magic was never instructed officially and openly in any medieval school or university in Europe—a large number of instructive cases will compensate the reader for the frustration caused by the lack of a department of necromancy: among them, a king summoning angels and peering into a crystal ball in order to learn the hidden intentions of his people and the secrets of the material world; an engineer designing terrifying siege-guns and powerful catapults, whose military manual contains the first medieval depiction of the Archimedes' screw, but also various magical methods to occupy castles (one of which requires the fat of a hanged man); an executioner and torturer who starts collecting handbooks on magic and reeducates himself as a magician; an alchemist of a royal court who finds the text of the Christian Mass the most convenient model for describing the secret process of transmutation; and a medical doctor educated in the best schools of Montpellier, on whose advice princes and peasants collected snakes and frogs with their bare hands and consumed them for medicinal purposes. Nevertheless, the main focus will be the university masters whose libraries include—besides a large number of scientific treatises—some surprising items pertaining to the field of learned magic: handwritten notes scattered in the blank pages of the codices on how to learn about the outcome of various enterprises or illnesses; human hands drawn with great care indicating the main lines of fate for the purposes of palmistry; texts of natural magic which include various recipes using animal substances used for magical purposes; the earliest surviving version of the great handbook of talismans and ritual magic, the *Picatrix*, which is in fact the only copy containing the illustrations of the half-animal half-human creatures described in the text; and finally the *Liber runarum* (The Book of Runes) containing the names of angels transcribed in Scandinavian runes, which bear special powers and are supposed to be engraved on talismans in order to activate their benign or malign influence. Thus, although Faustus probably never studied magic in Kraków, Prague, or Buda, it is possible to compile a bibliography of the texts he would have used if he had.

For the sake of clarity, the texts under investigation will be classified into certain categories. The first comprises the relatively innocent practices of natural magic, which operate through the secret correspondences of the world and the hidden

properties of objects. Then come the more manipulative methods of image (in other words, talismanic or celestial) magic, which work with names and figures engraved in specific stones and metals. The last is that of ritual (or ceremonial) magic, which relies on the invocation of angels and demons, and which is somewhere on the borderline between magic and religion. These categories, with which I will operate throughout my study, will be carefully defined in the Chapter 1. For the moment, it is enough to emphasize that although the threefold distinction of natural, image, and ritual magic is a helpful framework for the classification of medieval magical texts,⁹ the borders between these subcategories will not always be clear.

It is much harder to account for the inclusion of two further categories, the divinatory material (including geomancy and palmistry) and the alchemical sources. These arts share with magic the characteristic of being frequently condemned; nevertheless, they were not necessarily seen as branches of magic, and—as it will be argued in due course—were condemned for reasons different from those marshaled against talismanic and ritual magic. But as the borderlines in the field of magic are fuzzy, I tended to be inclusive rather than exclusive. Therefore, divination is also incorporated in this study, considering the fact that texts on divination often traveled together with texts on natural and image magic. Evidence of alchemy, as provided by a couple of Central European sources, will also be presented, first because it seems to supplement the picture on the readership of magic in that era, and second because I—like most modern readers—am somewhat imprisoned in the modern categorization of magic, which undeniably includes alchemy. It is important to always bear in mind that the modern and medieval categories of magic, science, and religion do not necessarily coincide.

No similar admission is made in this book regarding purely astrological texts, even though nowadays astrology might also seem to be a part of magic. It is of primary importance to remember that there is no necessary link between the two fields. Astrology was taught in certain universities,¹⁰ magic never, or at least not as part of the curriculum. Even though certain elements of astrology provoked serious

9. When applying this distinction, I generally follow the structure of two recently defended doctoral dissertations: Frank Klaassen's "Religion, Science, and the Transformations of Magic: Manuscripts of Magic, 1300–1600" (Ph.D. diss., Department of History, University of Toronto, 1999)—its published version is forthcoming in the *Magic in History* series by the Pennsylvania State University Press, and Sophie Page's "Magic at St. Augustine's, Canterbury, in the Late Middle Ages" (Ph.D. diss., Warburg Institute, University of London, 2000). It is worth adding, however, that Frances Amelia Yates has already applied a somewhat similar threefold typology to her Renaissance material: natural-celestial-ritual magic. See, for example, Frances Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1964).

10. On general overviews concerning the role of astrology (interrelated with astronomy and medicine) in university curricula and the medieval philosophy of nature, see Richard Lemay, "The Teaching of Astronomy in Medieval Universities, Principally at Paris in the Fourteenth Century," *Manuscripta* 19 (1975): 197–217, and Lemay, "The True Place of Astrology in Medieval Science and Philosophy:

theological debates, such as the concept of the Great Year (which implied that earthly history is fundamentally periodical, which contradicted the teaching of the church)¹¹ and the effect of the stars on particular events and on human free will,¹² general astrological principles in a more innocent form were relatively well accepted as a part of medical training, and as functional elements of natural philosophy.¹³ The idea that the incorruptible, perfect, and divine celestial regions exercise an influence over the corruptible earthly bodies was supported not only by the arguments of Aristotle and Ptolemy—the two main authorities of antiquity in the field of celestial sciences—but also by empirical evidence. Celestial causal superiority is evident in the influence of the sun on temperature, rain, and the cycle of seasons; or the power of the moon on the ebb and flow of the tides; not to mention that a sophisticated system had been worked out relating the sections of the zodiac, the planets, and the various parts of the human body. In addition, experience—understood in the medieval sense of the word—suggested that celestial virtues influenced metals (think of the behavior of the magnet, which was a frequent subject in the discussions of natural philosophy), and the association of planets with metals (the sun with gold, the moon with silver, and so on) was regarded as valid in general, not just in alchemical considerations.

Second, astrology is excluded for regional reasons: although the readers and scribes of magical texts in Central Europe were often concerned with the celestial sciences, and are to be found among the circle of university professors, students of astrology, and courtly astrologers, this correlation does not work in the other direction: the majority of these astrologers were not involved in magic. In brief, astrology was a fully fledged discipline in its own right in the fifteenth century, but magic was never officially studied or practiced, and if certain philosophers (who will be introduced in the next chapter) proved tolerant of some of its forms, magical texts never entered the university curriculum. Therefore, I will frequently touch upon the issue of astrology while looking at the use and the codicological context of magical works, but I will not, however, include astrological sources in the textual analysis.

Towards a Definition,” in *Astrology, Science and Society: Historical Essays*, ed. Patrick Curry (Woodbridge: Boydell, 1987), 57–73. On the requirements expected from a doctor to lecture in astrology at Bologna, see Lynn Thorndike, ed., *University Records and Life in the Middle Ages* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1944; repr., New York: Octagon Books, 1971), 282.

11. Edward Grant, *Planets, Stars, and Orbs: The Medieval Cosmos, 1200–1687* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 498.

12. Krzysztof Pomian, “Astrology as a Naturalistic Theology of History,” in *Astrologi Hallucinati*, ed. Paola Zambelli (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1986), 29–43.

13. Edward Grant, “Medieval and Renaissance Scholastic Conceptions of the Influence of the Celestial Region on the Terrestrial,” *Journal of Medieval and Renaissance Studies* 17 (1987): 1–23; John D. North, “Medieval Concepts of Celestial Influence: A Survey,” in Curry, *Astrology, Science and Society*, 5–18.

Further limitations to this study are linguistic. The focus of the research is predominantly on Latin texts. This is not due to the complete lack of vernacular sources. Although no such examples have been found in Hungarian, the fifteenth century no doubt witnessed the translation of divinatory and natural magic texts into German and Czech. Again, these sources will not be ignored completely; however, proper research into the vernacular texts of learned magic (finding the Latin original, identifying the additional elements coming from local sources, and so on) would require a separate study.¹⁴

Nevertheless, the presentation and close reading of basic texts form only the first objective of my investigations. Once the examples of magic have been collected, and their codicological contexts examined (to determine which texts travel alone in the manuscript tradition, and which ones occur together with other genres), the main concern of the book is to explore and characterize the circle of people who wrote, copied, collected, used, and read these manuscripts to the extent that the evidence will permit. The historian's work is then to identify which texts travel independently in the codices, and—provided two or more magical texts find themselves bound together regularly—what characteristics of theirs made the collector believe that they belong together.¹⁵

While only in some exceptional cases are the specific owners known, it is often possible to identify the social stratum to which they belonged. Richard Kieckhefer calls the owners and users of manuscripts of magic the “clerical underworld”;¹⁶ others attribute this practice generally to the lower clergy.¹⁷ William Eamon speaks about the rise of an “intellectual proletariat, a group composed of university-educated laymen who had failed to find useful or permanent employment.”¹⁸ An “underworld of learning,” clerics, medical doctors, and members of universities

14. For research on German divinatory texts, see, for example, Elisabeth Wade, “A Fragmentary German Divination Device: Medieval Analogues and Pseudo-Lullian Tradition,” in *Conjuring Spirits: Texts and Traditions of Medieval Ritual Magic*, ed. Claire Fanger (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1998), 87–109.

15. This is one of the main focuses of Frank Klaassen's “English Manuscripts of Magic, 1300–1500: A Preliminary Survey,” in Fanger, *Conjuring Spirits*, 3–31. As Klaassen stresses, even the manuscripts without any identified owner “give us access to the world view of their authors, scribes and collectors, and frequently betray a great deal about these individuals their professions, names, education, status, or relative wealth” (3).

16. Richard Kieckhefer, *Magic in the Middle Ages* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 151–75.

17. See, for example, Stanisław Bylina, “La prédication, les croyances et les pratiques traditionnelles en Pologne au bas Moyen Âge,” in *L'Église et le peuple chrétien dans les pays de l'Europe du Centre-Est et du Nord (XIV^e–XV^e siècles)* (Rome: École française de Rome, 1990), 301–13.

18. William Eamon, *Science and the Secrets of Nature: Books of Secrets in Medieval and Early Modern Culture* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1994), 69. Eamon refers to R. R. Bolgar, *The Classical Heritage and Its Beneficiaries* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1954), 178. See also Alexander Murray, *Reason and Society in the Middle Ages* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1978), chap. 9.

could have been the real necromancers and practitioners of magic, or at least the readers of occult texts. Their curiosity in experimental and occult studies, their education, profession, background, convictions, and wishes can be inferred from the books they collected. And then, reconstructing the university careers, training, interests, and libraries of the compilers and owners of the given texts helps us understand the role of the magical books that lined their shelves and the place of magical beliefs in their conceptual schemes.

Similar questions are to be raised in a Central European context. What is known about the people who wrote, copied, and used magical texts? Did Central Europe have its own magicians, or was the presence of sources on magic nothing more than the result of simple incidental curiosity of well-known intellectuals at the universities and the courts? In other words, in what stratum of the social hierarchy should one look for the readers: among the anonymous clerics and ordinary masters, or in the group of highly respected scholars? Did the scribes add their own inventions to the field of magic, or did they merely follow Western practices? Did they belong to the local “clerical underworld”? (And on a more general level: what are the boundaries of this underworld?) Furthermore, were the compilers and the collectors educated at Polish, Bohemian, or Hungarian universities? Did they possess such handbooks for personal use or out of pure curiosity?¹⁹

Throughout this study, “Central Europe” will designate the geographical and political entity that lies beyond the limits of the first expansion of the Western barbarian peoples, the Carolingian Empire, but which did not belong under the direct sphere of Byzantine influence, and could therefore join Western Europe around A.D. 1000. (This happened simultaneously with the process of the North’s inclusion in the enlarged notion of the West, while Southeastern Europe found itself under the aegis of Byzantium.) Central Europe comprises the countries of three Christian states, whose political developments show genuine resemblances: Poland, Bohemia, and Hungary. Strictly speaking, the territory covered here should be referred to as “East-Central Europe,” since what is usually understood as “Central Europe” is supposed to include Austria, Italy, and—partially at least—Germany as well. In the following, however, for the sake of simplicity and brevity, I will refrain from operating with such difficult expressions. I will apply the simpler term “Central Europe” when referring to Poland, Bohemia, and Hungary, not denying the fact that this notion has been the subject of long theoretical debates.²⁰ Since my

19. This approach is in many ways similar to that of the scholars dealing with the “history of reading.” See Guglielmo Cavallo and Roger Chartier, eds., *Histoire de la lecture dans le monde occidentale* (Paris: Editions du Seuil, 1997), and Roger Chartier, *L’Ordre des livres* (Paris: Alinea, 1992).

20. The classic study on the internal borders of Europe and on the medieval notion of Central Europe is Jenő Szűcs, “The Three Historical Regions of Europe: An Outline,” *Acta Historica Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae* 29 (1983): 131–84. Further considerations on this issue, with special

research is related to the medieval emergence of courts, institutions, and libraries, by and large I will concentrate on Kraków, Prague, and Buda, not neglecting of course towns of lower political significance, insofar as ecclesiastical formations and book collections can be associated with them.

As far as manuscripts are concerned, the eastern boundary of Central Europe is very clear: beyond this region sources are written in a different language; they belong to a different manuscript tradition, even though occasionally this border is permeable.²¹ The southern borders are more cultural than political: while the history of medieval Croatia is closely associated with that of Hungary, and consequently falls under the scope of the present inquiry, Istria and Dalmatia had a separate history in the Middle Ages, dominated by Italian influence. Therefore, the famous alchemical text *Pretiosa margarita novella*, composed in Pula by Petrus Bonus, a native of Ferrara, will not be treated together with Bohemian, Polish, and Hungarian sources on alchemy.²²

attention to the patterns of university foundations in the region, are Gábor Klaniczay, "Late Medieval Central European Universities: Problems of their Comparative History," in *Universitas Budensis, 1395–1995*, ed. László Szögi and Júlia Varga (Budapest: Bak-Fisch, 1997), 171–82, and "Medieval Central Europe: An Invention or a Discovery?" in *The Paradoxes of Unintended Consequences*, ed. Lord Dahrendorf, Yehuda Elkana, et al. (Budapest: CEU Press, 2000), 251–64. On the birth of medieval Central Europe, see also Aleksander Gieysztor, *L'Europe nouvelle autour de l'An Mil. La Papauté, l'Empire et les "nouveaux venus"* (Rome: Unione Internazionale degli Istituti di Archeologia, 1997). For a helpful historiographic survey on the formation of the idea of Central Europe in the secondary literature, see Gábor Klaniczay, "The Birth of a New Europe about A.D. 1000: Conversion, Transfer of Institution Models, New Dynamics," in *Eurasian Transformations, Tenth to Thirteenth Centuries: Crystallizations, Divergences, Renaissance*, ed. Johann P. Arnason and Björn Wittrock (Leiden: Brill, 2004).

21. William Francis Ryan has researched Eastern Slavic (especially Russian) magical sources; see especially *The Bathhouse at Midnight: An Historical Survey of Magic and Divination in Russia* (Stroud: Sutton, 1999), and "Magic and Divination: Old Russian Sources," in *The Occult in Russian and Soviet Culture*, ed. Bernice Glatzer Rosenthal (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1997), 35–58. See also the following: Ihor Ševčenko, "Remarks on the Diffusion of Byzantine Scientific and Pseudo-Scientific Literature Among the Orthodox Slavs," *Slavonic and East European Review* 59 (1981): 321–45; Mirko Dražen Grmek, *Les sciences dans les manuscrits slaves orientaux du Moyen Âge* (Paris: Université de Paris, 1959); and Grmek, "Les Sciences chez les Slaves au Moyen Âge," in *Histoire générale des sciences*, vol. 1, *La science antique et médiévale*, ed. René Taton (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1966), 557–67.

22. Still, if someone is interested in science and magic in Dalmatia, the following will be helpful: Žarko Dadić, *Egzaktne Znanosti Hrvatskoga Srednjovjekovlja* (Zagreb: Globus, 1991), and Mirko Dražen Grmek, "The Life and Astrological-Medical Ideas of Federik Grisogono of Zadar," *Medical Journal* (Zagreb) 92 (1970): 34–42. For a helpful bibliography of Grmek's further works related to this field, see Danielle Gourevitch, ed., *Maladie et Maladies: histoire et conceptualization: Mélanges en l'honneur de Mirko Grmek* (Geneva: Librairie Droz, 1992), xvi–xlv. A potential reader interested in Petrus Bonus of Ferrara might want to consult Chiara Crisciani's study, "The Conception of Alchemy as Expressed in the *Pretiosa Margarita Novella* of Petrus Bonus of Ferrara," *Ambix* 20 (1973): 165–81.

The western boundaries of my region are somewhat less clear, and defined according to different, rather practical considerations. Eastern Germany, Austria, and Italy are historically and politically closely related to Hungary, Bohemia, and Poland. Culturally, these countries formed an organic unity; Polish, Bohemian, and Hungarian students frequently studied in German and Italian universities, while German and Italian humanists and professors often came to Central European institutions. Apparently, political boundaries did not present any obstacle. However, the source materials provided by Italy, Austria, and Germany are substantially different both in quantity and quality. In the present study, I intend to rely on a well-defined and delimited Polish, Bohemian, and Hungarian sample. It follows that I will not present a systematic survey of the magical manuscripts of Vienna²³ or Erfurt,²⁴ for example, because such an attempt would go beyond the scope of a single book, but whenever the traces lead to the West, I intend to follow them naturally, and I will include occasionally material from beyond the western limits of my area. The reason for this is that Central European universities were founded at much the same time and in much the same way as the universities of the German-language area (Heidelberg, Cologne, Leipzig, and Erfurt), and that political boundaries did not stop the wandering students of the fifteenth century. Their “homeland”—the university—was an international formation,²⁵ and they traveled freely, without paying much attention to national divisions, carrying their books, that is, my sources, with them.

Having thus acquainted ourselves with the idea of Central Europe, it is still not quite clear why this region should be treated separately as far as the texts of learned magic are concerned. In other words: what is so distinctive in this region with respect to the field of magic?

Two answers can be given to this question. The first is related to a tendency already pointed out by the scholarship dealing with the diffusion of Arabic magical texts in Western Europe: copies of magical texts “found an attentive audience only after about . . . 1400 in Central Europe.”²⁶ Put differently, the answers to the questions posed in this book can be found in fifteenth-century manuscripts. The second characteristic feature of this area is a relative tolerance shown toward texts

23. The exclusion of Vienna may seem particularly arbitrary, since the University of Vienna was founded roughly the same time as the universities of Prague, Kraków, and Pécs, and Vienna itself lies almost two hundred kilometers east of Prague, and thus must be considered Central European. My reasons, I repeat, are merely functional; Vienna alone possesses more extensive manuscript holdings than all the libraries where I carried out systematic searches.

24. A fruitful field of research might be based on the twenty treatises on magic in the fifteenth-century library of Erfurt. See David Pingree, “The Diffusion of Arabic Magical Texts in Western Europe,” in *La diffusione delle scienze islamiche nel Medio Evo Europeo*, ed. B. Scarcia Amoretti (Rome: Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei, 1987), 58 n. 1.

25. On the metaphor, see Klaniczay, “Late Medieval Central European Universities.”

26. Pingree, “Diffusion,” esp. 79 and 59.

on learned magic. This tolerance—which I definitely do not want to overstate—is to be understood by Western European standards. While in Paris, statutes and theological declarations condemning various forms and practices of magic were issued one after the other in the later Middle Ages, in Central Europe it was apparently without the slightest sign of fear of prosecution that university students and professors kept magical items in their libraries.

Because the two phenomena are closely related, they can be investigated in parallel. In order to understand why magical texts arrived in Central Europe with such a considerable delay, it is necessary to observe the particular traits of the intellectual history of the area. Roughly speaking, the use and copying of magical texts presupposes the presence of a certain learned culture, and the emergence of a sufficient number of learned scribes, compilers, and book collectors to sustain such a culture requires an intellectual milieu that only universities, monasteries, and royal or episcopal courts can provide.

The date suggested as the arrival of the magical texts in Central Europe coincides with the time of the reorganization of the University of Kraków (originally founded in 1364). After the death of its founder, King Casimir the Great, the university fell into a state of decline that ended only thanks to a new stimulus received from Queen Jadwiga, in the last years of the fourteenth century. This renewal opened up a golden age in the life of the university, in which, in the first half of the fifteenth century, two private chairs were founded especially for the studies of astronomy and astrology. These chairs yielded many new astronomical and astrological works, and provided the history of science with several generations of astronomers, while supplying various clerical and secular courts of Central Europe with thoroughly trained astrologers. Because of this flourishing, the University of Kraków became an international center of astronomy as well as of astrology, and it had an extensive relationship with other centers in Bologna, Paris, Vienna, and the royal court of Matthias Corvinus, king of Hungary. Probably without exaggeration, the contemporaries merely noted that “Kraków is stuffed with astrologers.”²⁷

The Prague milieu, in contrast, was somewhat less astrologically oriented. On the one hand, interest in alchemy was already present in Bohemia two hundred years before its late sixteenth-century apogee at the time of Emperor Rudolf II. This interest or even practice of the science of alchemy was probably stronger than a pure curiosity on the part of a confined intellectual circle, because we have an alchemical work dating from the middle of the fifteenth century written in the vernacular, that is, in Czech.²⁸ On the other hand, natural and image magic, as

27. “Cracovia astrologis referta est.” Aleksander Birkenmajer, *Études d'histoire des sciences en Pologne*, *Studia Copernicana* 4 (Wrocław: Zakład Narodowy im. Ossolińskich, 1972), 491.

28. See Chapter 5, note 41, and the accompanying text.

well as divination, are well represented in the manuscript collections of the first university of Central Europe in Prague. Apart from the university, the monastic context must have also provided fertile ground for an interest in magic: a number of magical texts have come to us from the Augustinian libraries of Třeboň and Brno.

Finally, the southernmost intellectual center of the time (no less interested in the celestial sciences) was the court of King Matthias of Hungary. King Matthias's enthusiasm for Renaissance Neoplatonic philosophy, his fascination with Hermetism, reflected also by the books of his famous Corvinian Library, his enthusiastic correspondence with Marsilio Ficino, the other Italian humanists staying and working in his court, are described by contemporary sources and researched by modern studies. According to Antonio Bonfini, one of the learned Italians staying in the royal household, members of the court were deeply concerned with Neoplatonism, and the names of Plato, Pseudo-Dionysus the Areopagite, Hermes Trismegistos, Zoroaster, Orpheus, Plotinus, and Pythagoras were mentioned in philosophical discussions on a day-to-day basis.²⁹ It is also often emphasized that King Matthias invited great experts of astronomy and astrology, such as the Pole Martin Bylica of Olkusz, the Königsberg-born Johannes Regiomontanus, and perhaps even the Italian Galeotto Marzio to the newly founded university in Pozsony (present-day Bratislava), the so-called Academia Istropolitana.³⁰ Astrology was taken so seriously that Matthias consulted his court astrologer before campaigns and had the horoscope of his new university prepared.

This was the institutional milieu that served as fruitful soil, not only for the development of the celestial sciences, but also for a deep interest in magic. The intellectual centers listed so far copied and produced a considerable number of texts belonging to each branch of magic. In various courts of kings, archbishops, bishops, dukes, and princes, as well as in the newly founded Central European universities, a new type of intellectual found himself in a peculiar and convenient place for satisfying his interest and getting involved in research.

Yet is it possible to claim that Central Europe was the birthplace of a "center of magical studies"?³¹

Anticipating one of the negative conclusions of my research (partly in order to avoid hasty misinterpretations), let me emphasize here that there is no reason to suppose that magic played any genuine role in late medieval Kraków, Prague, or

29. Antonius Bonfini, *Symposium de virginitate et pudicitia coniugali*, ed. Stephanus Apró (Budapest: K. M. Egyetemi Nyomda, 1943), 119–20.

30. Ibid.

31. The expression "center of magical studies" is used by David Pingree for the late medieval St. Augustine's Abbey in Canterbury after he had identified a number of manuscripts of learned magic as having belonged to certain identifiable monks of the monastery (Pingree, "Diffusion," 94). Concerning these texts and their owners, as well as the extent to which "center of magical studies" can be applied to St. Augustine's Abbey, see Page, "Magic at St. Augustine's," chap. 1.

Buda. Interest in various forms of magic did not constitute a unified or coherent movement either inside or outside the courtly and university life. If we take the extant manuscripts as starting points, and plot their locations on a map of Europe, we will see that Central Europe—especially Kraków—deserves special attention. By pursuing these lines further, we can then address the general issues of who produced and preserved these sources. On the other hand, however, if we proceed in the opposite direction, and wish to provide a general picture of the intellectual activity of the region, we can talk about a strong, consistent concern in astrology, but this claim cannot be extended to the question of magic, examples of which will remain relatively scattered and isolated.

The succeeding chapters follow the former of the two procedures. I start with a careful study of the sources themselves, presenting the main genres of magical literature one by one, then describe the extent to which the categories are represented in the surviving Central European source material, and examine whether the texts are mere imports from the Western manuscript tradition, or whether one can find local products, examples of “original” texts. The codicological context of the particular magical texts will also be questioned as veritable sources: the position of certain kinds of magic in the framework of learning can be better understood on the basis of the tracts that occur or travel together with them. In addition, an *excursus* departing from the main body of the argumentation of the book will focus on the visual material contained in the sources.

Part Two concentrates more on the human and institutional elements. Two chapters will be devoted to the role that magic played in monastic milieus and royal courts, while a third will survey the patterns of the founding of universities and go deeper into the secrets of the personal libraries of university professors and students. Special attention will be paid in two *excursus*, first to the question of the criminalization of practice of magic, and the dangers awaiting those who did not make a secret of their interest in the occult, and second to the transformation of the figure of the magician, as demonstrated by a historical example closely related to the Kraków material. Here is where we return to the person of Faustus.

The present work can expect basically two kinds of readers: the first has a good knowledge of the sources and genres of magic, but is supposedly less acquainted with the history of local universities and royal courts. The second is more familiar with these latter questions but does not necessarily recognize every magical text by its incipit. I have tried to find a way between the Scylla of leaving my audience uninformed and basic subjects unexplained and the Charybdis of boring some readers by too much popularization. I have had to repeat facts that are widely known in the Western scholarship of learned magic in order to introduce and characterize the categories I operate with. In a bibliographical essay, for example, situated at the end of the book, I have provided short overviews surveying the findings and

the main tendencies of the secondary literature of the given branches of magic. These fairly conventional summaries are not meant to be significant contributions to scholarship, their purpose is to provide background knowledge for the readers who may need it. Similarly, my description of the foundation and early history of Central European universities will not contribute anything new to what has been said about the intellectual history of the area; however, I still needed to give some information on the milieu before getting to the subject of the private libraries of university people.

Remaining with the question of the readership of this book, I must also take into consideration the linguistic barrier that separates the three Central European countries from their German-speaking neighbors. The secondary literature and the primary sources of Austria, Germany, and Italy are accessible for the well-prepared modern scholar, but the same is not necessarily true for the Polish, Bohemian, and Hungarian material used in my work. One of my intentions and a *raison d'être* of this book is to provide this hypothetical scholar with further research tools.

CONCLUSION: SEVEN QUESTIONS

My inquiries have had a twofold objective. First, I intended to provide a catalog and an analysis of the texts of learned magic that have survived in Central Europe, and second, I wished to characterize the circle of those persons who can be related to these magical texts. These two objectives can be divided into two sets of questions.

To provide a catalog and an analysis of the texts of learned magic that have survived in Central Europe, it was necessary to ask:

1. What texts of magical content (belonging to the fields of natural, image, and ritual magic, as well as to those of alchemy and divination) can be found and identified in the manuscript collections of Central Europe?

2. What texts that have not survived, but which surely existed, since we have evidence of their fifteenth-century existence from the extant source material, can be identified?

3. And to what extent does this group of magical texts represent an “original” intellectual production of this region? In other words, were these texts written in this region by local authors, or were they simply imported from the West by local scribes?

To characterize the circle of those persons who can be related to these magical texts, it was necessary to ask:

4. Who are those persons who were in one way or another responsible for the emergence of the magical sources, that is, who were their authors, scribes, owners, readers, and users? How can we describe the circle of these persons? Were they magicians, outsiders, marginal figures living on the periphery of society, or ordinary monks, average courtiers, and everyday university people?

5. What was the place of learned magic in their interest: primary or accidental? Why were these sources copied or written: to put them into practice or just for contemplation? Did any reader wish to apply the divinatory methods, talismanic instructions, and ritual invocations? Or did magic simply belong to a pure “academic interest” of the collectors?

6. Remaining still with the issue of the collectors' fascination for magic, one can ask a question that might be considered both anachronistic and naive, and yet everyone dealing with medieval texts of magic will sooner or later ponder on it. Why didn't these collectors see that it was impossible to learn the seven liberal arts through the prayers of the *Ars notoria*, that it was impossible to expel scorpions from Bath or destroy cities with the help of Thebit's *De imaginibus*, and that the magnet does not say anything about the chastity of their wives? Or should we rather suppose that the methods did actually work in their time?

7. And finally, did the scribes, collectors, and authors of magic texts form a coherent group of practitioners, or a company of interested friends? Did they copy the texts from each other's codices, did they discuss the content, did they put this content into practice together, or were they isolated intellectuals with no visible connections?

Let us see systematically what the answers to these questions are, as offered by my research.

1. I believe that my study has convincingly shown that Central European manuscript collections offer fewer, but an equally rich variety of, magical texts as Western European libraries. Polish, Bohemian, and Hungarian scribes and collectors included natural and image magic, alchemy and divination, as well as various types of ritual magic in their codices not just by mere chance. This is the region which preserved, *inter alia*, the first long version of the famous handbook of magic, the *Picatrix*, which is also the only illustrated copy we have, and two of the four extant copies of the *Liber runarum*, a short tract combining Hermetic talismans with Scandinavian runes. In addition, this part of Europe gave birth to the following: a unique version of ritual magic, the prayer book of King Wladislas, which incorporates crystallo-mancy, and long paragraphs of the *Liber visionum* of John of Morigny; the *Bellifortis* of Conrad Kyeser, a source of technology and military engineering that is rich in magical elements; the *Antipocras* of Nicholas of Poland, a theoretical work on the borderline of medicine and natural magic, which recommends its reader to consume snake flesh for medicinal purposes; and Nicolaus Melchior's *Processus*, which combines the text of the Christian Mass with the alchemical process. These four texts of "local authorship" inspired wide interest among Western scholars, too.

The only category of texts missing from these manuscripts was necromancy *per se*, the genre which contains long invocations to benign and malign spiritual agents, offers explicitly demonic procedures, and operates with an inventory of magic circles, animal sacrifices, suffumigations, summoned and bound demons, and so on. (To be sure, texts of image magic may also contain such elements, although in different contexts and in different concentrations.) However, demonic magic was fairly rare even in the West; texts such as the Munich manuscript published by Richard

Kieckhefer and the MS Rawlinson 252 are considered singular survivors, and it is by no means surprising that no such examples have been found so far in Central European manuscript collections.

2. Some of the extant source materials contain clear indications that certain other magical works were in use and had been read in late medieval Central Europe. Precise textual borrowings in the *Bellifortis* attest that Conrad Kyeser, when writing and compiling his work, had in front of him a copy of the *Liber vaccae*, and two texts attributed to Albertus Magnus, the *Experimenta*, and the *De mirabilibus mundi*. We have every right to suppose that the latter two texts were consulted with great attention also by Nicholas of Poland, the doctor from Montpellier. The *Liber visionum* of John of Morigny, a (perhaps incomplete) copy of the *Ars notoria*, and some further magical and crystallomantic texts were without doubt on the table of the author of the prayer book of Wladislas, who incorporated long paragraphs from these sources in his handbook. Nicholas the Hangman and Henry the Bohemian were both accused in Kraków of possessing magical books (one of these was written by a certain Matthias, a necromancer); and even though these books cannot be identified today, we may suppose that they belonged to the field of ritual magic. Finally, the author of the short book list of the Dresden manuscript—whom I believe to have been the scribe of the codex, Egidius of Corintia—was well acquainted with the eleventh chapter of the *Speculum astronomiae*, where the author of the *Speculum* establishes the classifications of Hermetic, Solomonic, and natural literature; he must have also read the *Picatrix*; and he seems to have had firsthand information about at least some of the magical and necromantic books he lists, such as the *Clavicula Salomonis*, the *Liber Semphoras*, the *Liber quattuor annulorum Salomonis*, the *De arte eutonica*, the *Liber ad demoniacos*, the *Liber machometi de septem nominibus*, the *Liber institutionis Raziel*, the *Liber lunae*, and the *Liber Almandel*. Even though these texts have no trace in the extant book collections, we can plausibly suppose that they were accessible for a Kraków student at the end of the fifteenth century.

3. It is perhaps naive but certainly reasonable to inquire about the originality of this wide range of magical texts. Bearing in mind that discerning between original authorship and mere compilation has little relevance in a medieval context in general, and therefore any answer to such a question is necessarily misleading, we can say that in the fields of medicine and astronomy, Central European scholars proved to be most fruitful and “original,” and their scientific outcome constitutes an important chapter of the history of science, but their texts on natural and image magic as well as on divination were, as a rule, mere reproductions of the well-known Western material. We have only a few, albeit striking, examples when a text is not a simple copy of an Italian, French, or German codex. Such examples are the *Bellifortis* of Kyeser and the royal prayer book of Wladislas—even though this book

is at least ninety-five percent compiled from other texts, the act and the aspects of the compilation can be regarded as “original,” which is the usual type of originality in the genre of ritual magic. Interestingly, alchemy proved the most inspiring topic for the authors of this region: besides reproducing Western texts, such as the works of Johannes of Rupescissa, Central European scribes had the opportunity to copy local products, too, whether they were the Latin works by Johannes Ticiensis, the Czech *Rightful Way* of John of Laz, or the alchemical process in the form of a Christian Mass by Nicolaus Melchior. While we have less reason to speak about Central Europe’s own group of *magician*-authors, the region certainly had a considerable number of practicing *alchemist*-authors.

4. Having identified the individuals who can be related to magic, we can observe that virtually none of them can be seen as a real outsider, that is, a marginal figure of the society. In Poland, Bohemia, and Hungary, we find mainly insiders related to manuscripts of magic: university professors, monastic figures, ecclesiastical and courtly officers, medical doctors, and engineers—that is, intellectuals whose activity was not monopolized by the topic of magic. Even Nicholas of Poland, whose medical methods and obsession with snake flesh shocked and terrified many, and caused no little scandal around Kraków, was a doctor trained in the best schools of his time, and nobody considered him an obscure magician.

Among the three places where readers of magic gathered—the monastery, the university, and the court—the monastic milieu yielded the least evidence for a reconstruction of some magical interest. Alchemy was certainly a recurrent concern for the monks of Central Europe (as it was for monks in the West), and so was natural magic (probably as a form of medical knowledge), but no monastery of the region can rival the richness of magic sources in St. Augustine’s in Canterbury. As far as one can judge from the extant list of titles, monastic libraries in Central Europe rarely included explicitly magical items. The courtly context was a much more fertile soil for a curiosity about learned magic, and this curiosity was not limited to telling the future. Courtly intellectuals were in the position of being able to read a wide range of magical materials, as it is attested by Wladislas’s prayer book, Kyser’s military handbook, and the court case of Henry the Bohemian, who was accused of invoking spirits in order to find treasure.

The greatest number of tracts, however, appears in the codices of the masters of the newly founded Central European universities, especially in the milieu of the chair of astrology in Kraków. The *Picatrix*, the *Liber runarum*, the *Experimenta Alberti*, and a variety of other magical works may be found in the late medieval professorial libraries of the region. To be sure, the predominance of university masters in the role of the collectors and scribes of magical texts might have several other reasons than their greater interest in magic. First, professors usually owned more books than other readers in the Middle Ages. Second, compared to other medieval

book collections, their libraries enjoyed the best chances of survival, and are consequently the easiest to reconstruct. Modern national libraries, such as the Biblioteka Jagiellońska in Kraków and the National Library of Prague, which were the main “suppliers” of this study, were originally based on private and institutional medieval book collections related to the university.

5. The fact that most texts of magic survived from the libraries of university people explains their codicological context, too. Generally speaking, works on natural magic and talismans became integral constituents of medical and astronomical manuscripts without being considered particularly magical or problematic, and this reflects the fact that they had an equally organic place in the scientific interest of the collectors. Analysis of the library of a Kraków student, Johannes Virdung of Hassfurt, has proven that a clear awareness of the magical character of talismans did not discourage some masters from including image magic in their books. Virdung’s collection of Hermetic and talismanic texts is especially rich even by Western standards. While we do not know whether he practiced the methods that he studiously copied on the blank folios between the scientific tracts, the great number of these texts, along with his later interest in the magicians of Europe, indicates that he was an attentive reader of image magic, and that he thus turned to the talismans with deep intellectual interest.

The scientific context of magical works is almost universal: texts of philosophy and theology rarely occur together with magic. Perhaps related to this fact, the theoretical reflections on magic, such as Al-Kindi’s *De radiis stellarum* and the *Speculum astronomiae*, also occur separately, never in the company of texts of practical magic. An exciting exception from this rule is the book list of magical works in the Dresden manuscript, which is copied in the company of astronomical, astrological, talismanic, and divinatory texts. This difference of codicological context is one of the reasons why I think that the book list was the scribe’s own intellectual production, with the purpose of orienting the reader in the mass of magical texts partly contained by the same manuscript.

In most cases, we are simply not in the position to decide whether the occurrence of a magical text in a codex indicates actual practices or simple curiosity. The *Picatrix* or Thabit’s *De imaginibus* contain no indication whether their readers constructed talismans. Some sources are, fortunately, more talkative. The long list of successive manuscript pages representing geomantic charts in BJ 793 among other examples, the sophistication with which these charts are elaborated, the indications and cross-references in the margins, and the omission of theoretical introductions to the methods of divination not only point to a general, theoretical interest in divinatory methods, but indicate expertise in their concrete application. In a word, I am convinced that at least some sections of BJ 793 were copied with the definite purpose of fortune telling. More interesting perhaps, actual use of ritual magic,

crystallomancy, and the invocation of angels may also be revealed. External evidence—legal documents and confessions—is not the only way to prove that someone attempted to apply the methods of crystallomancy and demon invocation; but internal evidence left in the magical texts may also show such application. As we have seen, in the case of the royal prayer book of Wladislas, the consequent substitution of the name of the operator implies that the text was prepared with the intention of making it suitable and ready for real use, and it was in all probability even consecrated.

6. Once we identified the collectors of natural magic, talismanic, divinatory, alchemical, and ritual magic texts as learned monks, court intellectuals, and university masters, that is, as intelligent individuals capable of reflection, it is rather obvious to inquire: how can we account for the fact that these persons were never faced with the problem that the methods they copied did not work in practice? Did they not see that the mechanism of magic is obviously false, and that its falsity can be easily shown with the help of simple experiments? Or did the methods perhaps actually work?

While such questions about the past might seem somewhat present-minded and thus illegitimate, the real danger is not to ask *questions* inspired by the concerns of the present (such important research fields as the history of women, childhood, or everyday life are typically inspired by the concerns of the present), but to give *answers* distorted by these concerns. We can therefore freely raise our naive questions, even though there is something anachronistic in such inquiries, we only have to be careful when answering them.

In fact, we are not looking for one single answer to explain why the methods of magic could have been seen as effective, but rather a group of interconnected answers. What we can claim in general, however, is that those magic practices surveyed in this book fitted quite well into the scientific-religious conceptual framework of the Middle Ages.

We have already touched upon the issue of efficacy in the case of talismanic magic in Chapter 3. There is no point in doubting that belief in the *general* protective power of talismans was prevalent in the Middle Ages, and, in addition, a number of stories support the idea that the same talismans were believed to have sufficient virtue for *concrete*—for instance military—purposes, too. It happened that women started feeling affection for someone, that castles were occupied, and that scorpion populations decreased. Success in such cases might have been attributed to magic. In other words: magic in some cases actually seemed to work. And this was closely related to the fact that processes of natural and talismanic magic were not as alien from the contemporary natural philosophy as they are from our modern natural science. The underlying assumptions behind the mechanism of talismans and magic stones, the occult virtue of herbs, and the healing power of animal substances formed

part of the same correspondential worldview that was typical of many fields of medieval science. Our first answer to the initial questions is therefore that in many cases users certainly regarded magic as effective.

But what happened when such a technique manifestly did not work? Here, we have to differentiate according to the type of magic we are discussing. Taking ritual magic first: to ask why its practitioner did not get disappointed when his prayers to the angels did not lead to success is quite the same as to ask religious persons whether they become atheists if God does not accomplish what is asked in the prayers. Faith needs obviously different kinds of proof—if it needs any. To construct scientific experiments with the intention of testing what percentage of prayers turns out to be successful—even though such an experimental approach was subject of fairly heated debate in late nineteenth-century England¹—sounds bizarre both in the fifteenth century and today.

To continue with the *experimenta* literature and the talismans, we see a more basic disagreement between the medieval and the present attitudes. The self-criticism and the readiness to exclude those methods which repeatedly failed to produce the expected results was not a particularly central idea in the natural philosophy of those times. As we have seen in Chapter 2, what counted as an experiment was not what was tested in a number of controlled experimental situations, but what the old philosophers and authorities described, and what was generally accepted about nature. Even for those philosophers who taught that demons—having exclusively spiritual and not corporal existence—are not perceivable, it was the experience, that is, the general conviction, that proved their existence.²

Against such a background, it is not surprising that relatively fantastic convictions could be considered through the centuries as sufficiently confirmed scientific facts.³ An instructive example is the conviction that magnets will loose their power of attraction if they are rubbed with garlic. This “fact” was repeated many times as a self-evident “proof” for the theory of antipathies by authors over fifteen centuries, from Plutarch to the sixteenth century. A convenient worldview (in this case the theory of sympathies and antipathies) and a sufficiently strong textual tradition became more efficient means for this conviction to gain epistemological status than practical tests. And—to complicate the problem—those who believed in the

1. Frank M. Turner, “Rainfall, Plagues, and the Prince of Wales: A Chapter in the Conflict of Religion and Science,” *Journal of British Studies* 13 (1974): esp. 64; quoted in Thomas F. Gieryn, “Boundary-Work and the Demarcation of Science from Non-Science: Strains and Interests in Professional Ideologies of Scientists,” *American Sociological Review* 48 (1983): 781–95.

2. On the modern history of the word experience, see Peter Dear, *Discipline and Experience: The Mathematical Way in the Scientific Revolution* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1995), esp. 11–25.

3. I would, however, definitely not wish to imply that this was true only in the Middle Ages and that modern science is free of theories that will someday seem fantastic and ridiculous.

magnet-garlic antipathy claimed to have tried it in practice. The same empirical argument that seems to us to disprove the theory became its actual proof. This changed only when the generally accepted ontology of the world was transformed and magnets and garlic were no longer seen as having antipathies and sympathies, but one of them as having magnetic force, and the other as being completely irrelevant as far as magnetism is concerned. Things are proved to be nonexistent and theories are proved to be false when they change their status in the classification of a new worldview.⁴

Finally, we hasten to add that in a number of cases experiments must have produced results that were seen as negative by the contemporaries, too. Even in such cases, however, it would be anachronistic to expect them to abandon the given theory; various strategies less drastic than rejecting the core hypotheses of magic were available to explain the failure. One could always argue that the operator had not sufficiently or correctly prepared to perform the given magical task: he had not fasted enough or attained a satisfactory level of bodily and spiritual purity. It was also possible to argue that the constellation at the moment of the experiment was not favorable. Or perhaps everything happened as it was described in the handbooks, only the person was not right one. Such experiments were not conceived in the democratic way of the modernity (according to which an experiment carried out under the same specified conditions can be repeated by anyone, anywhere, regardless of gender, race, and origin): only the initiated, the adepts, could perform them, and the pupils were not necessarily in the possession of such abilities. If the given result was expected from a helping angel or demon, the argument could have been made that the spirits were able, just not willing, to do what had been required from them. Finally, one could always say that the instructions—originating usually from texts written several hundred years earlier—were not understood properly (just as we have serious problems in understanding Galileo's descriptions of experiments), or that the text was simply not transmitted—copied or translated—correctly (as the talismans of the magic squares were copied indeed with many errors).

All in all, there are many reasons why the methods of magic described in the handbooks could not be falsified, and even though I do not exclude that there may have been some skepticism about some methods, in general, there is no reason to doubt that most of these texts were copied with a fairly strong conviction that the methods written in them would work.

7. The last issue to be addressed here concerns the relations and links of the persons who can be associated in one way or another with learned magic. To put it differently, the question is whether any cooperation, correspondence, or intellectual contact of magicians is detectable. If so, it remains for us to speculate whether we

4. Daryn Lehoux, "Tropes, Facts, and Empiricism," *Perspectives on Science* 11 (2003): 326–44.

can claim that any of the intellectual centers—courts, cloisters, or universities—of the region were particularly magical in nature, and with this we have returned to the initial question of the book: could Faustus have studied magic in Kraków, if he had turned up there?

The historical Faustus probably never went to Kraków not only because magic was not studied publicly there in the late fifteenth century, but also because that city did not yet have the same magical fame it was to have one hundred years later. The pieces of evidence collected during my research do not support the assertion that Kraków offered an intense magical milieu to its visitors at that time—while it undeniably offered a particularly strong astrological environment. My conclusion is that however ample the evidence we have concerning an intellectual interest in learned magic in Central Europe, and especially in Kraków, there is no sufficient reason to call any of the intellectual foci and institutions a “center for magical studies,” and no coherent and institutional study of magic is detectable in the region.

Still, although there was no public chair of learned magic in the heart of the University of Kraków, we can point to the presence of some important cooperation related to magic. It can be reconstructed in detail that in the early fifteenth century Henry the Bohemian worked together with other university people, a certain Stanislas, the Italian professor Monaldus of Luca, and the Polish Nicolaus Hinczonis of Casimiria, on his crystallomantic treasure-finding projects in the royal gardens.

Sixty years later, Johannes Virdung of Hassfurt copied talismanic texts in the same year and from the same sample book as another student of the university, Egidius of Corintia. Whether they were acquainted cannot be proven, but the similarities of their interests and the resemblance of their manuscripts suggest at least some intellectual contact, and one can easily imagine how they got involved in the discussion of the content of the *Liber runarum* or of the Hermetic *Liber de stellis beibeniis*. Virdung's manuscripts and Egidius's Dresden codex both contain representative selections of texts on image magic and Hermetism and surprisingly similar collections of astrological texts. In addition, Egidius's list of magical titles testifies to a certain theoretical interest in the issue of classifying magical texts, which may have also easily been a topic discussed among the students of the University of Kraków. We cannot reconstruct the rest of Egidius's life, but we know that Virdung, upon returning to Germany, took steps to become acquainted with all of his contemporaries who were interested in magic on a technical or on a spiritual level. Thus, he was in contact with Abbot Trithemius, the English necromancer Nicolaus de Pulchro Monte Schonberg, and the humanist Konrad Celtis (who had also been a student at Kraków). He probably also met Johannes Mercurius and Georgius Faustus.

If we remain with the question of the cooperation among “magicians” and the transmission of magical ideas and texts, we cannot discount the effects of Italy and

Germany. The Bohemian alchemist John of Laz claimed to be a pupil of a certain Antonio of Florence, killed in Bohemia because of his alchemical practices. In Kraków, the Italian Monaldus of Luca took part in the treasure-hunting practices of a circle of university masters around Henry the Bohemian. In Hungary King Matthias was in correspondence with Marsilio Ficino, whose pupil and fellow in the Florentine Academia Platonica, Francesco Bandini, even visited the royal court of Buda; another Italian Platonist, Callimachus spent several years at the University of Kraków. Last but not least, the mysterious BJ 793, containing many texts on image magic and divination, as well as the *Picatrix*, is probably a copy of an Italian codex. Italian masters and manuscripts seem to have played a crucial role as external factors promoting the Central European reception of learned magic, which reception was also facilitated by the fact that students of the region often visited Italian universities. The role of Germans was somewhat different, rather modeled by the Faust legend. Konrad Celtis and Johannes Virdung of Hassfurt as young students went to Kraków, and although they did not study magical arts at the university, they clearly got involved in learned magic, and the manuscripts they found in Kraków became a source of their fascination with certain genres of magic.

One of the reasons why Central Europe could have seemed an adequate place for a student to satisfy his interest in magic, and why especially the University of Kraków could have been an institution where magical texts were frequently copied, could be the relative tolerance of magical activity in the region. I am still not arguing that Central Europe provided the students and courtiers with a particularly magical milieu as compared to Western Europe; however, it is undeniable that it was a relatively calmer place with regard to criminalization. The practice of magic *did* lead to court cases in several occasions—as we have seen in the cases of Nicholas the Hangman and Henry the Bohemian—but there were no such severe condemnations on the part of the university or other authorities as we can observe in contemporary Paris.

A second—rather global—reason for the emergence of magical texts in the fifteenth century might be a general European tendency, namely that from the twelfth century on certain forms of magic had more and more opportunity to cross the borderlines of legitimate science. It seems that the notions of both science and magic were (and are) historically changing, dynamic constructions, and it was not *ahistorically* given what counted as scientific knowledge teachable at universities and what was excluded as dangerous and harmful, and what was seen as rational enterprise and what was considered irrational. While arguments against certain practices and ideas related to magic reflect a growing severity, more and more frequently other forms of magic in other sources were labeled as scientific. This tendency—called the “positivization of magic”⁵—can be well exemplified by such classifications

5. I am quoting again Claire Fanger’s terminology, as I did in Chapter 1. See also Chapter 7.

as that of Conrad Kyeser or the author of the Dresden book list, where alchemy, theurgy, and certain forms of natural and image magic appeared as respectable elements of science.

It was due to this process that leading intellectuals were provided with ample opportunity to find a legitimate and scholarly approach to dealing with magical methods. As a result, the readers of magic in Central Europe are not to be looked for primarily within the circles of the Faustus or Mercurius-type of full-time, semi-literate, and self-made magicians, nor in that of anonymous university members whose number “outran the demand” and who remained without jobs. Partly because local higher education started functioning in the Central European area relatively late, there was no time in the fifteenth century for the emergence of a surplus of university masters and an “underemployed and largely unsupervised clerical underworld,” as had happened in the West.⁶ As nearly as we can reconstruct the picture, the late medieval collectors and readers of magical manuscripts of the region belonged to a high and respected intellectual stratum, benefited from the tolerant milieu of the Central European universities and courts, and apparently did not feel obliged to lock the door of the room in which they kept their books of secrets.

6. Kieckhefer, *Forbidden Rites*, 12.

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